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AI



Sundar Pichai is ‘very excited’ about Google Cloud’s OpenAI partnership



Google CEO Sundar Pichai says he is “very excited” to supply OpenAI, the search giant’s largest competitor in AI, with cloud computing resources to train and serve the company’s AI models as part of a recently struck partnership.

“With respect to OpenAI, look, we are very excited to be partnering with them on Google Cloud,” said Pichai on Google’s second-quarter earnings call on Wednesday. “Google Cloud is an open platform, and we have a strong history of supporting great companies, startups, AI labs, etc. So super excited about our partnership there on the cloud side, and we look forward to investing more in that relationship and growing that.”

IMAGE CREDITS:  
JOSHUA M. FLORES / GETTY IMAGES

The comment came shortly after analysts peppered Pichai and other Google executives with questions about how AI would affect its core search business and why Google is spending an extra \$10 billion on capital expenditures this year to catch up in the AI race. Roughly two and a half years since the launch of ChatGPT, Google has now shifted its focus squarely on developing leading AI models and products to compete with OpenAI.

ChatGPT is a major threat to Google Search, but the OpenAI deal marks a massive new customer for Google Cloud. It’s a treacherous relationship for Google to navigate; OpenAI may ultimately use Google’s cloud infrastructure and chips to upend the company’s core Search product.

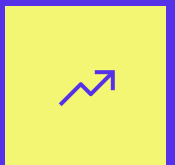
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Earlier this month, OpenAI [quietly added Google Cloud to a public list of suppliers](#) that it uses for cloud computing services, alongside Microsoft and Oracle. Reuters previously reported in June that OpenAI was considering tapping Google Cloud for [extra computational power](#).

Notably, Google Cloud revenue soared in the second quarter of 2025 to \$13.6 billion, up from \$10.3 billion in the same quarter last year. Google attributes a significant chunk of that growth to the Google Cloud Platform and other products it offers to AI companies. Google Cloud is still a small business relative to Google Search, but it seems to be growing in the AI era.

Several large AI labs have tapped Google Cloud as a cloud computing partner, including Anthropic, Ilya Sutskever's Safe Superintelligence, Fei-Fei Li's World Labs, and now OpenAI. Pichai noted on the earnings call that the company has been successful at winning deals with large AI labs thanks to its large supply of Nvidia GPU chips and in-house TPU chips.

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Google Cloud seems like a smart partner for OpenAI. The startup is extremely constrained when it comes to Nvidia GPUs, which it uses to train new AI models and serve them to hundreds of millions of users. Those constraints have been a [major tension point with OpenAI's biggest backer and largest cloud computing partner, Microsoft](#), forcing the ChatGPT maker to turn to its competitors in the cloud market.

On the AI products front, Google seems to be doing better than initially expected. The company said its AI chatbot, Gemini, now reaches 450 million monthly active users, and [AI Overviews reaches 2 billion monthly active users](#). However, the business around these products remains unclear, as does the share of queries they're taking from Google Search.

It's hard to imagine that Pichai is truly that excited about working with OpenAI, a company that represents the biggest threat Google Search has ever faced. The partnership is reminiscent of Google's deal with Yahoo from decades ago, when it was just a startup, and used Yahoo's homepage as an accelerant to overtake it as the front door to the internet. How lasting OpenAI's relationship with Google is remains to be seen.

Topics: [AI](#) [Google](#) [Google Search](#) [OpenAI](#)

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## Google wants Search to be more like an AI assistant in 2025

Maxwell Zeff — 6:02 PM PST · February 4, 2025

Google Search is in the midst of a “journey” around AI, Google CEO Sundar Pichai said during the company’s earnings call on Tuesday. [The start of that journey was AI overviews](#), a controversial and

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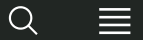
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Google has been on this path for a few years now, ever since the search giant was caught flat-footed by the release of OpenAI's ChatGPT in 2022. The shift has massive implications for websites that rely on Google's traffic and businesses that buy ads on Google Search.

Not everyone is happy about it, but Google is pushing ahead.

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When asked about the future of AI and Search, Pichai said, “You can imagine the future with [Project Astra](#),” a reference to DeepMind’s multimodal AI system, which can process live video from a camera or computer screen and answer user questions about what the AI sees in real time.

Google has big plans for Project Astra in other parts of its business too. The company says it wants the multimodal AI system to power a pair of [augmented reality smart glasses](#) one day, which Google will create the operating system for.

Pichai also mentioned [Gemini Deep Research](#) — an AI agent that takes several minutes to create long research reports — as a feature that could fundamentally shift how people use Google Search. Deep Research automates work that people have traditionally done with Google Search. But now it seems Google wants to do that research for users.

“You are really dramatically expanding the types of use cases for which Search can work — things which don’t always get answered instantaneously, but can take some time to answer,” said Pichai. “Those are all areas of exploration, and you will see us putting new experiences in front of users through the course of 2025.”

Pichai said further that Google has a “clear sense” of the Search experiences it could create with another one of Google’s AI agents, [Project Mariner](#). That system can use the front end of websites on behalf of users, making it unnecessary for people to use websites themselves.



Google’s CEO also said there’s an “opportunity” around letting users interact more and ask follow-up questions with Google Search. Pichai was light on details there, but it sounds like Google is considering ways to make its Search interface more like a chatbot.

“I think the [Search] product will evolve even more,” said Pichai. “As you make it more easy for people to interact and ask follow-up questions, etc., I think we have an opportunity to drive further growth.”

Today, ChatGPT has matured into one of the internet’s most used products, with hundreds of millions of weekly users. It presents an existential threat to Google Search’s long-term business. To address it, Google is not only building a competitor AI chatbot with Gemini, but also injecting AI features directly in Search.

Of course, the first step on Google Search’s AI journey did not go very well. When Google rolled out AI overviews to all of Google Search, the system displayed inaccurate and weird AI hallucinations. These included answers that told [people to eat rocks and put glue on their pizza](#). Google admitted at the time that [AI overviews needed some work](#).

Despite this negative rollout, it appears Google is just getting started putting AI into Search.

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## Microsoft now lists OpenAI as a competitor in AI and search

Maxwell Zeff — 10:55 AM PDT · August 1, 2024

Microsoft has a long and tangled history with OpenAI, having invested a [reported](#) \$13 billion in the ChatGPT maker as part of a long-term partnership. As part of the deal, Microsoft runs OpenAI's models across its enterprise and consumer products and is OpenAI's exclusive cloud provider.

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However, the tech giant called the startup a “competitor” for the first time in an [SEC filing](#) on Tuesday.

In Microsoft’s annual 10K, OpenAI joined a long list of competitors in AI, alongside Anthropic, Amazon, and Meta. OpenAI was also listed alongside Google as a competitor to Microsoft in search, thanks to OpenAI’s new [SearchGPT feature](#) announced last week.

It’s possible Microsoft is trying to change the narrative on its relationship with OpenAI in light of antitrust concerns — the FTC is [currently looking into the relationship](#), alongside similar cloud provider investments into AI startups. Microsoft recently [agreed to give up its board observer seat at the startup](#) — a seat it gained after a kerfuffle last fall when OpenAI’s board briefly fired CEO Sam Altman, prompting Microsoft CEO Satya Nadella to offer him and other top execs jobs at Microsoft.

However, SEC filings like this are often places where corporations throw out hyper-cautious warnings to investors.

Partners and competitors are certainly not mutually exclusive titles in Silicon Valley. In the year 2000, the dominant search engine at the time, Yahoo, announced an agreement to let Google’s search results appear on its web page. The two companies were partners for a few years, until Google ate Yahoo’s lunch in search and became the unofficial, but dominant, doorstep to the internet. The two companies were partners, but were still threats to each other. (Yahoo is the owner of TechCrunch.)

There’s enough history of this kind of power-switch in tech that it’s at least conceivable that Microsoft and OpenAI’s relationship will take a similar route.

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Regardless, Microsoft is not putting all its eggs in one basket.

In March, Microsoft [hired the co-founders of billion-dollar AI startup Inflection AI](#), Mustafa Suleyman and Karén Simonyan, to lead its new Microsoft AI division. The cloud provider is investing heavily into Microsoft Copilot and building out an AI future that's entirely separate from OpenAI.

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